Project Alpha: Charter & Milestones

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Executive Summary

Project Alpha will deliver an internal knowledge assistant that helps employees find answers across approved company documents and workplace systems. The first release focuses on reliable retrieval from PDF policies, with answers linked to document names and page numbers. Later phases may connect approved applications after security and access reviews.

Problem Statement

Employees spend time searching scattered policy documents and asking colleagues questions that have already been answered. Search results can be incomplete or outdated, and users need a way to inspect the original source before acting on an answer.

Goals and Success Measures

Goal	Measure	Initial target
Find policy answers faster	Median time to locate a supported answer in pilot testing	Under 2 minutes
Improve traceability	Answers with a valid source document and page reference	At least 95%
Reduce unsupported claims	Test questions where system correctly says evidence is insufficient	At least 90%
Support reliable ingestion	Valid sample PDFs processed without unhandled errors	100% of pilot set

Scope

In scope for the pilot: PDF upload or local document ingestion, page-by-page text extraction, metadata and content hashing, retrieval from indexed documents, source-backed answers, basic evaluation tests, and a simple web interface.

Out of scope for the first release: autonomous changes to company systems, sending messages on behalf of users, unrestricted internet search, processing confidential documents without authorization, and guaranteed correctness for legal or HR decisions.

Milestones

Milestone	Target date	Deliverable / exit criteria
M1 — Foundation	30 Oct 2026	Repository structure, Python environment, sample PDFs, and tested PDF text extraction.
M2 — Retrieval API	6 Nov 2026	FastAPI endpoints, document chunks, metadata, and repeatable retrieval tests.
M3 — Answer generation	13 Nov 2026	Answers grounded in retrieved text with source document and page references.
M4 — Web integration	20 Nov 2026	MERN interface integrated with Python service and basic conversation history.
M5 — Pilot evaluation	27 Nov 2026	Evaluation report, known limitations, security review, and demo-ready pilot.

Responsibilities

Role	Responsibility
Project Sponsor	Approves scope, priorities, and pilot acceptance criteria.
Project Lead	Owns milestones, risks, coordination, and weekly status reporting.
AI / Backend Engineer	Implements ingestion, retrieval, API contracts, evaluation, and source references.
Web Engineer	Builds the user interface, integrates the API, and handles user-facing error states.
Security Reviewer	Reviews permissions, document access, secret handling, logging, and data retention.

Risks and Mitigations

- **Incorrect or unsupported answers:** retrieve source passages, display citations, test common questions, and abstain when evidence is insufficient.
- **Outdated policies:** record document version and ingestion timestamp; define a process for replacing superseded documents.
- **Unauthorized access:** restrict ingestion to approved documents and preserve source permissions in later integrations.
- **Schedule overrun:** prioritize PDF retrieval and traceability before optional connectors or automation.
- **Prompt injection inside documents:** treat document content as untrusted data, not as instructions that override system rules.

Acceptance Criteria for Pilot

- The system can extract text from the three agreed sample PDFs and report extraction errors clearly.
- A test set of questions has expected source documents and page references.
- The assistant returns source-backed responses or clearly indicates when the available documents do not contain the answer.
- No live company credentials or real personal data are included in the test corpus.

Governance Note

Northstar Systems and Project Alpha are fictional. Dates, targets, policies, names, and metrics in this document are invented for software testing. Treat this PDF as sample data, not as a real corporate commitment.